

Daily Bible Note

Date: June 24, 2026

I. Today's Reading

NKJV: Jonah 4:1-11

1 But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he became angry.

2 So he prayed to the Lord, and said, "Ah, Lord, was not this what I said when I was still in my country? Therefore I fled previously to Tarshish; for I know that You are a gracious and merciful God, slow to anger and abundant in lovingkindness, One who relents from doing harm.

3 Therefore now, O Lord, please take my life from me, for it is better for me to die than to live!"

4 Then the Lord said, "Is it right for you to be angry?"

5 So Jonah went out of the city and sat on the east side of the city. There he made himself a shelter and sat under it in the shade, till he might see what would become of the city.

6 And the Lord God prepared a plant and made it come up over Jonah, that it might be shade for his head to deliver him from his misery. So Jonah was very grateful for the plant.

7 But as morning dawned the next day God prepared a worm, and it so damaged the plant that it withered.

8 And it happened, when the sun arose, that God prepared a vehement east wind; and the sun beat on Jonah's head, so that he grew faint. Then he wished death for himself, and said, "It is better for me to die than to live."

9 Then God said to Jonah, "Is it right for you to be angry about the plant?" And he said, "It is right for me to be angry, even to death!"

10 But the Lord said, "You have had pity on the plant for which you have not labored, nor made it grow, which came up in a night and perished in a night.

11 And should I not pity Nineveh, that great city, in which are more than one hundred and twenty thousand persons who cannot discern between their right hand and their left—and much livestock?"

II. Key Summary

- Jonah reveals in 4:2 that his original flight to Tarshish was deliberate — he knew God was gracious and merciful, and he did not want that grace extended to Nineveh.
 - God responded to Jonah's anger not with condemnation but with two quiet questions (4:4, 4:9), then arranged a plant to grow over Jonah and a worm to destroy it the next morning.
 - The book closes with God's unanswered question (4:11): if Jonah could feel grief over a plant he never planted, how could God not have compassion for 120,000 people He created?
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III. Passage Analysis

Jonah's Anger: It Was Always About Himself

"He was hostile to the city of Nineveh, and still held a Jewish and carnal view of God."
[1]

Jonah sat outside the city, waiting for its destruction — not hoping for the people's good, but for his own prophecy to be vindicated and his reputation protected. His anger wore the language of theology, but underneath it was a simple calculation: his pride mattered more than those lives.

The Plant Lesson: God's Compassion Has No Borders

"It is not because these people had any inherent worth — it is that they mattered profoundly to God's heart. Every one of us is precious to the living God, treasured by Him." [2]

God did not argue with Jonah directly. Instead, He let a plant grow and die to put a single question on the table: if you can genuinely grieve over a plant you never tended, how could I not care about 120,000 people I created? The book ends without Jonah's reply — because the question is still open, and it is addressed to us.

IV. Reflection Question

Have you ever seen someone you dislike get something good and felt, somewhere inside,

that they just didn't deserve it?

Jonah knew God was "gracious and merciful" — and was furious precisely because God showed that grace to his enemies. God's question to Jonah stands: "Is it right for you to be angry?"

References

[1] BibleHub.com, Keil and Delitzsch Commentary,

<https://www.biblehub.com/commentaries/jonah/4-1.htm>

[2] 華人基督徒查經資料網站, 巴斯德《歸納性研經》,

<https://www.ccbiblestudy.org/Old%20Testament/32Jonah/32GT04.htm>